

took him to the All England final earlier this year. And there's Ayush Shetty, a 21-year-old who has been handed the most daunting possible introduction to a home World Championships.

His first opponent is China's Shi Yu Qi, the defending champion and the world No. 1. Ayush, in contrast, is unseeded.

It's a daunting draw, but the enormity of the challenge also presents an opportunity for Ayush.

Ayush's breakthrough came at the Asian Championships in Ningbo in April, where he reached the final. Yu Qi beat him there, but their previous encounters had been considerably closer. And the Chinese has not been invulnerable this season. Former national chief coach U. Vimal Kumar believes that makes the opening-round tie more interesting than the seedings suggest. "That's the toughest it can get. But in a way, it's also a possibility for Ayush to create an upset," Vimal says.

For inspiration, Ayush need look no further than Lakshya, his compatriot at the Centre for Badminton Excellence in Bengaluru. Last year, Yu Qi defeated Lakshya in the opening round. Earlier this year, Lakshya reversed the result at the All England and reached the final. Now, Ayush gets his chance to do the same.

National coach Pullela Gopichand, too, sees the upside of having the world No. 1 so early. "It is better that Ayush faces Shi Yu Qi in the first round instead of the later rounds. It gives him a chance to take him out early if he pulls off the upset," Gopichand says.

Lakshya, meanwhile, has a less forbidding start but potentially a much harder road beyond it. The 14th seed could encounter Olympic silver medallist and former world champion Kunlavut Vitidsarn in the pre-quarterfinals.

The current state of men's singles, though, will give India hope. The field is packed with players capable of beating one another, with even the top names inconsistent. Lakshya has demonstrated that he belongs



in that group. His run at this year's All England, where he defeated both Yu Qi and Li Shi Feng, was a reminder of what he can do when his movement, defence and attacking game come together. The question is whether he can sustain it for seven days in New Delhi.

In contrast to the men's singles, the women's singles competition has a clear favourite in Korea's An Se Young. She has been the gold standard in the discipline over the

Doubles threat: India's highest-seeded entry at the World Badminton Championships will be the men's doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, who are seeded fifth. GETTY IMAGES

past couple of years. But while she is the gold standard, recent injury concerns — An pulled out of her last couple of tournaments — add an element of uncertainty.